EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

What Did Saadiah Gaon Teach Us?

Emunot VeDeot, Key Takeaways

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: The whole sefer: the Introduction and Essays 1 to 10, a review of the key takeaways

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 19 January 2026, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Why Review?

The Gemara says that one who learns and does not revise is like someone who ploughs the ground and does not plant seeds. "An essential part of learning is also *chazarah*, to revise and to go over." So before moving on, the Rabbi went through the entire sefer essay by essay, with the main points he had noted from each.

What comes next

- **Monday nights:** a new sefer, **HaMaspik l'Ovdei Hashem** of Rabbeinu Avraham, the son of the Rambam, starting **Monday 2 February**. There would be no shiur the following Monday, to give the Rabbi time to prepare.
- **Tuesday nights:** once the Rambam's Introduction to Perek Helek (the *ikkarim*) is finished, in a month or so, the class will begin the **Moreh Nevuchim**. "At least we get the best of both."

The Introduction: What Belief Is

"Many of the key points of Saadia in Emunot VeDeot actually appear in the introduction."

Four kinds of people

People go wrong in their beliefs either because they never think about belief at all or because they don't know what they are looking for. "Saadia loves categorizing with numbers," and already here there are four kinds of people:

1. Those who have reached the truth and are confident in it.
2. Those who have reached the truth but are unsure and doubtful.
3. Those who hold false beliefs and think they are correct.
4. Those who keep changing their minds, jumping from one opinion to another.

So he wrote the book so that people could know what the truth is and be confident in it. That is why, whenever he brought an opposing argument, he took the time to show why it is or is not correct.

Belief takes work

It is natural to have doubts at first. We cannot expect Hakadosh Baruch Hu to hand us all theological and philosophical knowledge "on a plate." As created beings, understanding the Divine takes time and effort, like everything in life.

For Saadia, **emunah is something a person has analysed**. "A belief without understanding isn't a belief." If you haven't thought it through and dissected it rationally and cogently, "that's not called an emunah." The word comes from **נאמן**, firm: **ותקעתיו יתד במקום נאמן**, a peg in a firm place, and **ומצאת את לבבו נאמן לפניך**.

Opinion does not make reality

"Mere opinion can't transform something into reality," which the Rabbi called something "lacking nowadays." The fool forms his opinions and then fits reality around them. The wise person forms his opinions after searching, research and analysis.

The four sources of knowledge

Saadia repeated this throughout the book:

#	Source	Example
1	**Sense perception**	What we see, hear and touch
2	**Self-evident reason**	Two plus two equals four
3	**Inference**, what we would call *binah*, **להבין דבר מתוך דבר**	You see smoke and infer fire
4	**Reliable tradition**	The chain from Sinai through the Nevi'im to the Chachamim

You must ask questions

At the end of the introduction Saadia says it is completely wrong to think one must not question. (The Rabbi recalled the "bizarre analogy" Saadia gave at the time, about people who think that if you go to India you will find money there.) Not only is it allowed; there is an **obligation** to analyse and understand, a point later repeated by Rabbeinu Bachya in Chovot HaLevavot and others. When Chazal warn against philosophising, that refers to philosophy alone, which can lead to wrong conclusions. When one has a received tradition and wants to understand it through philosophy, one is obliged to.

Eight reasons people deny the truth

"Basically all apply nowadays, some more than others":

1. The truth is too hard, too **inconvenient**, to accept.
2. **Stupidity.**
3. People are **too busy** with work and mundane affairs to think.
4. People are **too lazy** to think.
5. **Arrogance**: thinking you know everything, so you never look at other views.
6. **Social influence** of disbelievers.

7. Being presented with a **shallow religion**. "That's what I call fast food Torah... lots of stories and jokes and things, and people think this is what Torah's about."
8. The **bad behaviour** of people who ostensibly observe the Torah.

Essay 1: Creation

Essay 1 is about the creation of the universe only; Saadia does not get to God Himself until Essay 2.

- **Creation from nothing.** Saadia believes clearly and strongly in **בריאה יש מאין**. The Rabbi noted that some, famously the Ibn Ezra, held that Hashem created from existing matter, Plato's view. Saadia rejects it.
- **Two main arguments:**
- **Design**, the teleological argument, "the most common argument in the Rishonim": there is too much design in the universe for it to have happened by itself.
- **Finitude**: everything physical in our universe is finite, so the universe too must have a beginning.
- **Twelve views** of how the universe came about, among them:
- **Plato:** God and pre-existing matter (*hyle*) existed eternally. "You're believing in something which you haven't seen... so why posit the *hyle*? Just posit God." And matter cannot exist without form.
- **The Hindus:** God created from Himself. Rejected.
- **The dualists** (Mani, the Gnostics): a god of light and a god of darkness. Then neither is perfect, since each limits the other.
- **The Atomists:** tiny particles came together. But who created the atoms?
- **Aristotle:** the world is eternal. "We don't know anything that exists which doesn't have a beginning."
- **How can something come from nothing?** "If we knew how to create something from nothing, we would be God." The Kuzari and Rav Yosef Albo later repeat the idea that to understand God completely you would have to be God.
- **No space or time before creation.** So the question "why did Hashem create the world then and not earlier?" is meaningless. (Saadia held the world was about 4,000 years old in his time.) He also allowed that there may be things outside our universe, but Hashem created what we can understand; beyond that is not for us.
- **Why create at all?** His main reason, which recurs later in the book: **להיטיב**, to bestow good on His creatures.

Essay 2: Hashem

- **Hashem is one, not two.** If there were two gods, neither would be complete or perfect. Here Saadia explains why Tanach sometimes uses the Name and sometimes *Elokim*.
- **No diversity in Hashem.** Saadia begins the concept of *yichud* that the Rambam later refines: Hashem is **חכם, יכול, חי**, wise, able and alive, all as one. A person can be clever and also handsome, but those are separate attributes. "That doesn't exist in God."
- **Against the Trinity,** with philosophical and scriptural arguments, including refutations of the verses Christians cited. "That was something big in his time."

- **All anthropomorphism is metaphor.** Saadia is "the very first of our Chachamim that we know" to state explicitly that every description in the Torah of God's **body**, **actions** and **feelings** is metaphorical: a hand, a leg, going up and coming down, anger, regret. The Torah uses metaphors deliberately, "because otherwise we couldn't talk about God."
- **Negative theology,** which the Rambam develops greatly in the Moreh. When we say **אל רחום וחנון**, we do not mean we understand His mercy and compassion. They are infinite, and the finite cannot grasp the infinite. We mean that He acts towards us in ways we perceive as merciful, and that He is "not not merciful." "I know it's hard to think in those terms."
- **The *Kavod*.** "The first thing I think which the Rambam would have disagreed with." When Moshe or Yeshayahu "saw" Hashem, Saadia says they saw the **כבוד ה'**, an image Hashem created in order to communicate with human beings. For the Rambam, prophecy is in the intellect; nothing is seen.
- **Hashem fills the entire universe,** even impure places, unlike some later Rishonim who held He is not present in impure places, which "theologically is very difficult."

Essay 3: Revelation

Once there is a universe and a Creator, "the natural follow on" is that He reveals His will.

- **Why mitzvot?** Hashem created the world to bestow good, and gave the Torah because what we earn ourselves is far more enjoyable.
- **Two kinds of mitzvot.** Saadia is "the first one, to the best of my knowledge," to make this distinction (the Rambam says basically the same in other words):

  מצוות שכליות, rational mitzvot: between people, and serving God.

  מצוות שמעיות, revealed mitzvot, which we could never have worked out: *shatnez*, kashrut and the like.
- **Reasons even for revealed mitzvot.** Strikingly, Shabbat is for rest and has social value, bringing people together. Some animals are forbidden so that we do not come to worship them.
- **Objective morality.** "Morality is not something which is relative." We would know the rational mitzvot even without being told, but we still need the Torah, above all for **structure**: when is murder murder, theft theft, adultery adultery.
- **Prophecy is verified by miracles.** "The second time where the Rambam clearly disagreed with Saadia." Not on its own (a miracle-worker who says to abandon the Torah is not accepted), but for Saadia the main proof of a prophet is a real miracle. The Egyptian magicians, whom the class had just read about in the parasha, acted **בלטיהם**, which Saadia understands as sleight of hand. A prophet knew he was speaking with Hashem by a pillar of *Kavod* above him.
- **Yonah.** A unique answer: Yonah did go the first time. He refused the second time, because he did not want Nineveh rewarded for its teshuvah.
- **The Torah has three parts:** commandments, reward and punishment, and narrative, which brings the first two alive.
- **Mass revelation. אתם ראיתם**: the Torah was given before a whole people, the only religion to claim that. The Kuzari later develops this argument.
- **The Torah will never be abrogated.** Saadia refutes seven arguments for its replacement, "obviously the basis behind the New Testament, the basis behind the Koran."

- **Incidentally:** animals that are slaughtered will be rewarded, which the Rambam strongly rejected. And Israel suffers as the chosen people to increase its future reward, as the Gemara has us tell a convert, "which needs to be understood."

Essay 4: Free Will

"Now that's all God. Now let's talk about us, humans."

- **The world was created for human beings,** who are elevated above all other creatures. The Rambam and the Ibn Ezra strongly disagreed. So only humans have free will.
- **Choosing defines an action.** Free will covers acting and refraining. An action is yours only if you chose it:

  שוגג: switching on a light on Shabbat because you forgot it was Shabbat, or thought it was allowed. You chose the act, so it has consequences: in the time of the Mishkan, a korban; and some poskim say one should write it down today, for when the Beit HaMikdash is rebuilt.

  מתעסק: leaning back on the switch by accident. You did not choose it, so it is not your action.
- **Proofs from all four sources of knowledge** that we have free will.
- **Our bad choices do not affect God.**
- **Foreknowledge.** Hashem knows the result of our choices: I can choose A or B, and Hashem knows I will choose A, of my own free will. The Rambam and others give different answers.
- **What would have happened anyway.** If I give charity, the poor man would have received it some other way; if I harm someone, he would have been harmed anyway. I am rewarded or punished because it came through me. "Many argue with this," as the class discussed.
- **Pharaoh's heart.** "Because it's this week's parasha." The Rambam, the Ibn Ezra and the Ramban each answer, and Saadia gives an answer "I haven't seen anyone else say": **ואני אחזק את לב פרעה** means Hashem strengthened him to stay alive through the plagues so that he would see all ten, not that He took away his free will.

Essay 5: Merits and Sins

- **Everything is recorded,** in a metaphorical book, and every action leaves an imprint on the soul.
- **Tzaddik and rasha by majority.** A tzaddik has more mitzvot, a rasha more aveirot, measured by importance, not number. Two categories only: above 50 per cent, reward in Olam HaBa and punishment for one's sins in this world; below, reward for one's mitzvot in this world and punishment in the next. Regret can change the status of a mitzvah or an aveirah.
- **Why tzaddikim suffer:** to pay for their sins before the next world, or to increase their reward there. This is also Saadia's explanation for the suffering of children, who bear no moral responsibility.
- **Perfection is possible. אין צדיק בארץ אשר יעשה טוב ולא יחטא** does not mean it is impossible to be perfect.
- **The four components of teshuvah,** which Saadia was the first to list and the Rishonim later develop: **regret, stopping, commitment for the future and confession.** And writing poetry about teshuvah helps one do teshuvah.
- **Punished in this world, always:** false oaths, perjury, murder and adultery. "I don't know anyone else who says this." **Rewarded in this world, always:** honouring parents, compassion

for animals and honesty in business, which "seems to go against the Gemara."

- **Five levels of teshuvah.** The best is in the same situation, at the same age and with the same ability; the lowest is just before death.
- **The *beinoni*,** exactly 50-50: Hashem's compassion tips him to the side of the tzaddik.

"Until essay five, the differences between Rambam and Saadia are very small. From here... the differences become quite big."

Essay 6: The Soul

- **Created with the body,** separated at death and reunited at the resurrection.
- **Its nature:** after going through various theories, "some of them quite difficult," Saadia concludes it is a fine, ethereal creation, finer even than the spheres, the source of speech and intellect, which functions only within the body.
- **Five names, one soul: נפש, רוח, נשמה, חיה, יחידה**. *Nefesh* for the appetites, *ruach* for the emotions, *neshamah* for the intellect, *chayah* because it lives forever, and *yechidah* because it is unique.
- **Why put so fine a soul in a body?** Because alone it cannot function or be rewarded, so it is for its good. Reward and punishment are for **body and soul together**, which the Rambam disputes.
- **The moment of death:** each person sees the angel of death, "the yellow angel of death with the blue eyes, holding a sword." We do not see the soul leave because it is transparent.
- **No reincarnation.** "Reincarnation is nonsense." There is no *gilgul neshamot*.

Essay 7: Resurrection

With Essays 7 to 9 Saadia turns to eschatology.

- **Two resurrections:** of righteous Jews in this world in the messianic era, and of all the righteous in the World to Come, the new world that will be created.
- **Against nature, not against logic.** Even someone burned to fine particles is not completely destroyed; something always remains, from which Hashem reconstitutes him. Since it is not against reason, you may not interpret it as metaphor.
- **When the Torah may be read non-literally:** only in four cases.
- It contradicts the senses: Chava as "mother of all living" cannot include animals.
- It contradicts reason: **אש אכלה**, God is not fire.
- Two verses contradict each other.
- It contradicts tradition: the Torah says forty lashes; the tradition is thirty-nine.
  Many verses in Yeshayahu, Yechezkel and the Nevi'im describe resurrection. If these are metaphor, "the whole Torah becomes a metaphor."
- **Details,** which Saadia believes though they are not sourced: the resurrected go straight on to the World to Come and do not die again; there is room for everyone; people recognise one another; they rise with their former blemishes, so their loved ones know them, and are then healed; and they eat, drink and marry, with free will, reward and punishment, and long lives.

Essay 8: Mashiach

- **The purpose of Mashiach** is to gather Am Yisrael and bring them to Israel. It runs through the Prophets, and logically it would be unjust for Hashem not to redeem us.
- **Two times:** earlier, if we do teshuvah; and the **keitz**, the final deadline, at which Hashem will bring us to teshuvah, "we'll have no option."
- **A date.** From three verses in Daniel Saadia worked out a date, which the class calculated at the time. "Saadia was clearly wrong with that date," and the class discussed whether it is appropriate to give dates, and why so many have been wrong.
- **Mashiach ben Yosef and Mashiach ben David:** first ben Yosef, the war of Gog and Magog, and his death; then ben David.
- **Fifteen proofs that Mashiach has not come,** necessary against Christianity's claim that he already had.

Essay 9: The World to Come

- **Proofs:** seven from reason, six from the Torah and four from the Chachamim.
- **A new world,** not yet created. Hashem did not create us straight into it because we must earn it ourselves.
- **Why the Torah does not mention it explicitly:** two reasons, because it is obvious, or because the Torah deals with the present world. The class looked at many other Rishonim on this.
- **Light and fire.** Reward is light and punishment is fire. People will not eat or drink but be sustained by the light. Gan Eden, Olam HaBa and Gehinom are the same place. No night or day, no seasons: continuous light.
- **Eternal punishment,** despite Hashem's compassion, so that no one can say, "Had You given us a greater punishment, I would have kept the mitzvot." It gives the greatest incentive.
- **Seven levels** of reward and of punishment.
- **Who sees whom:** the wicked see the righteous and despair; righteous people close in level see one another; the wicked do not see each other.
- **Service of Hashem, and reward and punishment, continue** in the World to Come, "the most astonishing claim."

"For me this was the most difficult essay, essay nine, to accept. How does he know all these things? Did he go and come back?" Some of it is his own belief, and some is sourced in the Torah and the Chachamim.

Essay 10: How to Live

The most important thing: **balance**. Thirteen things, each with its place: abstinence, eating and drinking, intimacy, passion, wealth, children, work and building, long life, authority and power, revenge, wisdom, worship of Hashem, and rest. "You need all these thirteen things in life, but they're mixed together, not necessarily equally." And balance runs through everything else too: in what we see, in music and in smell. With that Saadia concluded the sefer.

The Shape of the Book

The Rabbi's map of the ten essays:

Essays	Theme
1 to 3	**God and revelation:** creation, the Creator, Torah and prophecy
4 to 6	**The human being:** free will, mitzvot and aveirot, the soul
7 to 9	**The end of days:** resurrection, Mashiach, the World to Come
10	**How to live in this world:** balance

Where Saadia and the Rambam part ways

Points the Rabbi flagged along the way:

Saadia	The Rambam
The prophets saw a created *Kavod*	Prophecy is in the intellect
Prophecy is verified by miracles	Disagrees
Slaughtered animals will be rewarded	Strongly disagrees
The world was created for man	Disagrees (with the Ibn Ezra)
Reward and punishment are for body and soul together	Disagrees
Olam HaBa is light and fire, with continued service of Hashem	Disagrees

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Closing

"That is a brief summary of everything which we learned over the last two years... It's been a fantastic journey together. Thank you everyone for coming along on this journey, because I've learned a lot over the past two years together."

Coming Up

- **Next Monday:** no shiur.
- **Monday 2 February:** the class begins **HaMaspik l'Ovdei Hashem** by Rabbeinu Avraham ben HaRambam. The Rabbi will post on the group where to get the best hard copy.
- **Tuesday nights:** the Rambam continues, with the Moreh Nevuchim to begin once the *ikkarim* are finished.
- *Chodesh tov.*

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/P3tnMvatx8Y · More shiurim: rabbikada.com